Nothing Has Happened Yet

Aryeh Leib Thorne Toren · Torah scholar, researcher and writer

Two short notes from Rashi sit five verses apart in today's portion. Read together, they describe two kinds of time.

The first is quiet time. Yitzchak has come to Gerar in a famine. When the locals ask about Rivka, he tells them, "She is my sister," the same answer his father gave in the same place years before. Then the Torah says: "When some time had passed." Rashi explains what that time did to him: "He thought, 'From now I need have no fear since they have not molested her up to now', and he was not sufficiently strict in guarding his actions."

Nothing had happened, so he concluded nothing would. That is what quiet does to a person. The danger hasn't gone anywhere. We have just stopped looking at it. And the one who noticed was the king of the Philistines, "looking out of the window."

The second is hard time. "Isaac sowed in that land and reaped a hundredfold the same year." Rashi stops on two phrases that look extra. "In that land": Gerar did not have the holiness of Eretz Yisrael proper. "In that year": it was "not a normal year, being a year of famine." Why tell us both?

לוֹמַר, שֶׁהָאָרֶץ קָשָׁה וְהַשָּׁנָה קָשָׁה

"To tell you that that soil was hard and that year was a hard one." And still he planted, and the field gave a hundred measures for every one they had estimated.

Put the two notes side by side and something surprising comes out. In the quiet stretch Yitzchak relaxed, and nearly brought guilt on his hosts. In the hard year he worked, and the blessing came. The famine didn't make him careless. The calm did.

We usually think the other way around. We brace for the hard years and rest in the easy ones. Rashi suggests that a hard year can be the one that gets our full attention and our best effort, and the easy stretch is the one to watch. "Nothing has happened yet" is no reason to stop guarding. "The ground is hard" is no reason to stop sowing.

One more detail. Why was anyone estimating the crop at all? Rashi brings the answer of our Sages: "the estimate was made for the purpose of the tithe". Yitzchak didn't measure to find out how rich he was. He measured so he would know what to give. In a famine year, in hard soil, the first question in that field was what belonged to others.

Today is Rosh Chodesh Kislev. A new month is a good moment for two honest questions. Where have I gone quiet because nothing has happened yet? And where am I holding back seed because the year looks hard?

Guard anyway. Plant anyway. And the verse itself tells us who sends the harvest: G-d blessed him.

Prepared in deep partnership and cooperation with Grok and xAI

All glory to the Ribono shel Olam · Errors are mine